MD OBAIDULLAH

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Education

PhD, Foreign Affairs — University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA *2026–2031*

Fields: Major: International Relations, Minor: Political Methodology

M.A., Political Science — University of Southern Mississippi, Hattiesburg, MS *2024–2026*

Thesis: Diversionary Repression in Electoral Autocracies: Crisis Onset, Loss-Domain Conditions, and State Escalation

Committee: Joe Weinberg (chair), Marek Steedman, and Maggie K. Martin

M.S.S., Public Administration — University of Barishal, Barishal, Bangladesh *2020–2021*

B.S.S., Public Administration — University of Barishal, Barishal, Bangladesh *2017–2020*

Monograph: Factors Shaping Citizens' Satisfaction with Local Governance: Evidence from Barishal Sadar, Bangladesh

Advisor: Tasnuva Habib Zisan

Research Interests

Substantive International Relations; International Conflict; International Security; Migration, Refugees, and Border Politics; Foreign Policy; Great Power Competition; Authoritarianism and Democratic Backsliding.

Methodological Quantitative and computational methods; causal inference; survey research and experiments; panel-data analysis; process tracing; comparative case studies; mixed methods.

Academic Appointments

2024-2026 **Visiting Scholar**, Department of Development Studies, Daffodil International University, Dhaka, Bangladesh

2024–2026 **Teaching Assistant**, Department of Political Science, University of Southern Mississippi, Hattiesburg, MS

2024 **Lecturer (Full Time)**, Department of Development Studies, Daffodil International University, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

International Relations and Political Science

[8] **Obaidullah, M.** (2027). The American touch: Evaluating the reach of U.S. soft power in India. *Journal of Countries Studies*, *5*(1), 21–66.

[7] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Begum, R. (2026). Regime collapse without civil war: Explaining Bangladesh's July 2024 uprising. *Asian Journal of Comparative Politics*. Advance online publication.

[6] **Obaidullah, M.** (2026). Machiavellian and Hobbesian foundations of democratic decline in Bangladesh. *Contemporary South Asia*, *34*(3), 554–579.

[5] **Obaidullah, M.** (2026). Delivering attraction? How BRI implementation shapes China's soft power in Bangladesh and Pakistan. *China Report*, *62*(2), 257–277.

[4] **Obaidullah, M.** (2026). Choosing not to choose: Qatar's hedging in the U.S.–China rivalry. *Journal of Countries Studies*, *4*(2), 335–371.

[3] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Howlader, M. R. (2025). Assessing geopolitical and socio-economic consequences of India–Bangladesh water disputes. *Discover Global Society*, *3*(1), Article 1.

[2] Sohel, M. S., Sifullah, M. K., Zaman, N. T., Hossain, B., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). Beyond borders: Mapping out the difficulties, stress, and coping strategies in transnational irregular (illegal) labor migration from Bangladesh. *International Journal of Community Well-Being*, *8*(2), 331–357.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, Hossain, M., Raihan, M. S., & Hossen, M. S. (2024). From humanitarian crisis to burden: Understanding the Rohingya refugee crisis in Bangladesh. *SN Social Sciences*, *4*(8), Article 141.

Public Health and Development

[6] Sifullah, M. K., Sohel, M. S., Jamil, S., Ahmad, B., Hossain, M. A., **Obaidullah, M.**, Zaman, N. T., Faruk, O., Islam, M. T., & Ali, N. (2025). WASH service accessibility and satisfaction among street informal workers in Dhaka City: A cross-sectional study. *Discover Social Science and Health*, *5*(1), Article 45.

[5] Sohel, M. S., Sifullah, M. K., Hossain, B., Sarker, M. F. H., Zaman, N. T., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2024). Exploring risky health behaviors and vulnerability to sexually transmitted diseases among transnational undocumented labor migrants from Bangladesh: A qualitative study. *BMC Public Health*, *24*(1), Article 1261.

[4] Mamy, M. M. B., **Obaidullah, M.**, Zaman, N. T., Saifullah, M. K., Sohel, M. S., Hossen, M., & Horaira, G. A. (2024). Navigating vulnerabilities: The untold story of informal households in Dhaka, Bangladesh during the COVID-19 pandemic. *New Zealand Journal of Asian Studies*, *26*(2), 75–98.

[3] Sohel, M. S., Alam, S., Rahman, M. M., **Obaidullah, M.**, Anam, A. S. M. T., Hossain, B., & Hossain, M. A. (2024). Exploring the multifaceted vulnerabilities of female street child labor in the capital city of Bangladesh. *Heliyon*, *10*(18), Article e37302.

[2] Sohel, M. S., Jamil, S., **Obaidullah, M.**, Hossain, B., Ali, H. M., Hossen, M. S., Uddin, M. S., Ahsan, T., & Eva, N. F. (2024). Healthcare challenges in disaster-prone riverine islands: A study of Sirajgonj, Bangladesh. *International Journal of Community Well-Being*, *7*(3), 491–515.

[1] Sarker, M. F. H., Ahmed, S. F., Kawser, U., Hossen, M. S., **Obaidullah, M.**, Khan, S., Sifullah, M. K., & Sohel, M. S. (2024). Is e-business breaking down barriers for Bangladesh's young female entrepreneurs during the COVID-19 pandemic? A qualitative study. *SN Social Sciences*, *4*(6), Article 107.

Book Chapters

[7] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Hossain, M. (2025). China's soft power strategy in the Middle East and East Asia: A comparative analysis. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–22). Springer.

[6] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Begum, R. (2025). The Rohingya crisis and its effect on Bangladesh–Myanmar bilateral relations: A historical analysis. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–19). Springer.

[5] Hossain, M., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). China's diplomatic approach to the Rohingya crisis: Balancing economic interests and humanitarian concerns. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–24). Springer.

[4] Sohel, M. S., Hossain, M. A., Sarker, M. F. H., Sifullah, M. K., **Obaidullah, M.**, & Ullah, A. A. (2025). Bangladeshi undocumented migration crisis in Europe: Implications of security, human rights, and policy. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–18). Springer.

[3] Sohel, M. S., Sifullah, M. K., Sarker, M. F. H., Hossain, M. A., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). Security questions explained: Irregular migrants to Europe. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–16). Springer.

[2] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Hossain, M. (2024). Major powers' approaches to the Rohingya crisis and their impact on Bangladesh. In A. A. Ullah (Ed.), *Handbook of Migration, International Relations and Security in Asia* (pp. 1–30). Springer.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Raihan, M. S. (2024). Soft power competition: A comparative analysis of China and the US in South Asia. In M. Zreik (Ed.), *Soft Power and Diplomatic Strategies in Asia and the Middle East* (pp. 197–226). IGI Global.

Book Reviews

[3] Hossain, M., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). Power of bonding and non-Western soft power strategy in Iran: Comparing China and India's engagement. *Contemporary South Asia*, *33*(1), 145–146.

[2] Hossain, M., & **Obaidullah, M.** (2025). We had the watches. They had the time: A witness account of the war in Afghanistan. *Small Wars & Insurgencies*, *36*(1), 241–243.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, & Hossain, M. (2024). Book review: Kudret Bulbul, Md. Nazmul Islam and Md. Sajid Khan (Eds.), *Rohingya Refugee Crisis in Myanmar: Ethnic Conflict and Resolution*. *Society and Culture in South Asia*, *10*(1), 142–145.

Journal Correspondence

[2] Jamil, S., **Obaidullah, M.**, & Alam, M. (2023). Unusual increase of cesarean section delivery in Bangladesh: Correspondence. *Annals of Medicine and Surgery*, *85*(5), 2242.

[1] **Obaidullah, M.**, Jamil, S., Mohammad Ali, H., & Akhter, A. (2023). Burning up: How heatwaves pose a threat to public health. *IJS Short Reports*, *8*(3), Article e0067.

Working Papers

Obaidullah, M. (2025). *India's Influence on Authoritarianism in South Asia: The Case of Sheikh Hasina's Bangladesh (2009–2024)*. (Under Review).

Public-Facing Scholarship (Selected)

Obaidullah, M. (2026). Asia's migrant workers need protection from Gulf wars. *The Diplomat*.

Obaidullah, M., & Hossen, M. S. (2026). Bangladesh's autonomy talk meets two hard deadlines. *The Insighta*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). The border killing fields separating India and Bangladesh. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). Invisible diplomats. *New Age*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). What if Iran's next target is the Gulf's water supply? *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). China quietly eclipsing a weakened Russia in Central Asia. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M., & Zobayer, A. (2026). Bangladesh first: BNP's path to a winning foreign policy. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). Why the EU–India trade deal could be bad news for Bangladesh. *The Diplomat*.

Obaidullah, M. (2026). Why China and Russia blinked as the United States moved on Venezuela. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2025). CPEC's Afghan push poses a new challenge for India. *East Asia Forum*.

Obaidullah, M. (2025). Turkey–Bangladesh air defense deal jolts South Asia's skies. *Asia Times*.

Obaidullah, M. (2025). India's opposition to Bangladesh's defense modernization is a self-defeating strategy. *The Diplomat*.

Fellowships, Awards & Funding

2026–2031	**Doctoral Funding Package in Politics**, University of Virginia — $37,080 annual living support, full tuition, health insurance.
2026	**John L. Nau III Graduate Fellowship**, University of Virginia — $5,000 education and research fund awarded in recognition of academic achievement and research promise.
2024–2026	**Graduate Teaching Assistantship in Political Science**, University of Southern Mississippi — $11,700 annual stipend, full tuition waiver.
2024–2025	**Outstanding Graduate Student in Political Science**, University of Southern Mississippi
2018	**CZM Genius Scholarship Recipient**, Center for Zakat Management, Bangladesh — $600 in merit- and need-based funding.

Conference Presentations

2026	Midwest Political Science Association Annual Conference
2025	Midwest Political Science Association Annual Conference

Teaching Experience

Term	Course	Instructor	Sections	Students
Daffodil International University — Lecturer (Tenure Track)				
Spring 2024	Introduction to Bangladesh Studies (BNS 101)	Obaidullah	6	300
University of Southern Mississippi — Teaching Assistant				
Fall 2025	Introduction to Law in American Society (PS 380)	Troy Gibson	1	35
Fall 2025	U.S. Constitutional Law (PS 480)	Troy Gibson	1	25
Fall 2025	Research Methods (SSGS 400)	Troy Gibson	1	40
2024–2025	American Government (PS 101)	Bob Press	3	150
2024–2025	Race and Ethnic Politics (PS 306)	Bob Press	2	70
2024–2025	Politics and Protests (PS 453)	Bob Press	1	20

Research Experience

2022–23 **Research Assistant**, BRAC James P Grant School of Public Health, Dhaka, Bangladesh (remote)

2021–22 **Research Assistant**, Centre for Advanced Research, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Editorial & Policy Experience

2025–2026 **Public Affairs and Consular Intern**, Bangladesh High Commission to the Maldives, Malé, Maldives (remote)

2024–25 **Commissioning Editor**, E-International Relations, United Kingdom (remote)

2021 **Policy Research Intern**, Youth Policy Forum (YPF), Dhaka, Bangladesh

Scholarly Service

Reviewer *BMC Public Health* (3); *SN Social Sciences* (2); *International Journal of Community Well-Being* (2); *International Journal of Sociology and Social Policy* (2); *PLOS ONE* (1); *PLOS Global Public Health* (1); *International Journal of Water Resources Development* (1); *Southeast Asia: A Multidisciplinary Journal* (1); *International Migration* (1); *Cogent Social Sciences* (1); *Journal of Further and Higher Education* (1); *Geoforum* (2); *Global Change, Peace & Security* (1).

Methods Training

2024 Data Analytics with R for Data Science, Statistical Research Consultants in Bangladesh, Dhaka, Bangladesh

2021 Qualitative Data Analysis Using NVivo, Centre for Advanced Research, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Skills & Languages

Languages	Bangla (native), English (fluent), Hindi (conversational), Arabic (basic)
Quantitative	R, RStudio, SPSS.
Qualitative	NVivo
Survey	Qualtrics
Research Tools	LaTeX, BibTeX, Zotero, Mendeley, Microsoft Office, Google Workspace.
Teaching	Canvas, Zoom, Google Meet.

Leadership & Community Engagement

2021–2022	**Joint General Secretary**, Bangladesh Youth Writers' Forum
2020–2022	**Campus Ambassador**, Youth Society for Research and Action (YSRA)
2019–2023	**Vice President**, National Human Rights Society Bangladesh, University of Barishal Chapter
2019	**Volunteer**, International Conference on Social Sciences and Law, University of Barishal
2018	**Class Representative**, Department of Public Administration, University of Barishal

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